

THIRD EYE | SHANKKAR AIYAR

Ideology Be Damned



Call it the arithmetic of politics or the politics of arithmetic. Ideology, the body of political belief, has been reduced into a convertible bond tradable at the exchange run by political dynasties. The definition of greater public good has long since blurred in the personal quest for votes. Now it is a chip that is available to be bartered for power or punted on the promise of electoral success.

The naked dance for power by the BJP and the JMM to the drumbeats of chicanery in Ranchi symbolises the arrival of convenience as conviction. In 2004, the BJP targeted the Congress for including Shibu Soren in the Cabinet. In 2010, despite his political infidelity, the BJP is willing for a remarriage. Lust for power is masquerading as affection for tribal interests.

It isn't just the BJP. A week before the Budget, the Opposition discovered the phenomenon of price rise and 'agitated' against it. On Budget day the entire Opposition—the SP and the RJD, flanked by the Left and led by the BJP—walked out of Parliament. Of course, the credo of greater common good lasted barely a few weeks. The SP and the RJD rediscovered communalism, and ditched the BJP and the Left, allowing the cut motion against price rise to fail. Food price inflation lost out to the threat of electoral deflation.

Bereft of new ideas, political parties are scrambling for identity and relevance. Since 1951, the decadal Census has been a sacrosanct instrument used to study demographic trends and the state of the nation. The founding fathers of the Constitution intended the Census to be just that. Last month, the regional one-caste dynasties and the Left—pretenders to the cult of a casteless society—led the excavation of caste as the instrument for accession of power. The six-decade-old dream of a casteless society was bartered for votes as the political class, including the Congress, forced the conversion of the sacrosanct census into a chapter on ancient sociology. The findings will be without doubt used to propagate voodoo economics in the name of uplifting the oppressed, backward classes.

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Yet, when and where it matters, don't ask, don't tell seems to be the essential mantra of India's political *gotras*. Every party wants to expand the reach of the proposed Food Security Act but none wants to probe and clean up the decrepit and scandalous public distribution system. Spend on poverty alleviation is over Rs 3,00,000 crore (Centre plus states), yet there is no demand for a mechanism to ensure outlays translate into measurable outcomes. Systemic inefficiency is a poll ally, an efficient instrument to garner votes.

In democracies elsewhere, change is the new hope and the vote the instrument. In India, tragically that very instrument is being subverted; means are now the political end.

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SIGNPOSTS

WON: By Viswanathan Anand, the FIDE World Championship at Sofia, Bulgaria, beating Bulgarian Veselin Topalov. This is



Anand's fourth world cup chess title since his first win in 2000.

APPOINTED: Nitin Nohria as the Harvard Business School's 10th Dean, making him the first Indian-American to occupy the post in the institution's 102-year old history.

DIED: Acharya Shri Mahapragya, the 10th acharya and supreme head of the Jain Swetambar Terapanth group. He was 91.

DIED: Actor Mac Mohan, 71, who played Sambha in the 1975 blockbuster *Sholay*. He debuted in 1965 and acted in over 175 films such as *Zanjeer*, *Don*, *The Burning Train*, *Shaan* and *Satte Pe Satta* in his 46-year career.

